The examination is being carried out on the **following application documents**

Description, Pages

1-10 as published

Claims, Numbers

1-14 filed with entry into the regional phase before the EPO

Drawings, Sheets

1/7-7/7 as published

1. Although claim 1 meets the requirements of Article 52(1) EPC with respect to the available prior art, amendment is required to overcome the objection below.

2. To meet the requirements of Rule 42(1)(b) EPC, the nearest prior art document mentioned in the Search Report (D1: EP-A1-1 243 875) should be identified in the description and the relevant background art disclosed therein should be briefly discussed.

3. Independent claim 1 is not in the two-part form in accordance with Rule 43(1) EPC, which in the present case would be appropriate, with those features known in combination from the prior art being placed in the preamble (Rule 43(1)(a) EPC) and the remaining features being included in the characterising part (Rule 43(1)(b) EPC).

Independent claim 1 should therefore be redrafted accordingly. In addition, the applicant should ensure that it is clear from the description which features of the subject-matter of claim 1 are already known in combination from EP-A1-1 243 875 (see Guidelines F-IV, 2.3.2).

4. The features of the all claims should be provided with reference signs placed in parentheses to increase the intelligibility of the claims (Rule 43(7) EPC). This applies to both the preamble and characterising portion (see Guidelines F-IV, 4.19).

5. Also, the description should be brought into conformity with the amended claims. Care should be taken during revision, especially of the introductory portion and any statements of problem or advantage, not to add subject-matter which extends beyond the content of the application as originally filed (Article 123(2) EPC).

6. The vague and imprecise statement in the description on page 10 (last two sentences) implies that the subject-matter for which protection is sought may be different to that defined by the claims, thereby resulting in a lack of clarity of the claims (Article 84 EPC) when the description is used to interpret the claims (see Guidelines F-IV, 4.4). This statement should therefore be amended to remove this inconsistency.